

hearsay. Probably the Magi began their propaganda generations later, whatever their private practice was. In regard of this custom, modern Parsism, which has preserved the *dakhma*—an eminently sanitary, inexpensive, and even decorous provision in a country where vultures may be commanded, however repulsive on the first impression—has repudiated the *khvetuk-das* as heartily as any outsider could expect. The fullest argument against the imputation that incestuous marriages were belauded as a religious duty, whether in the Avesta or in the Pahlavi books, may be seen in a monograph by the distinguished editor of the Dînkart, Darab Dastur Peshotan Sanjana, *Next-of-kin Marriages in Old Irân* (London, 1888). It must be admitted, I fear, that the learned Dastur's argument against the evidence of classical authors is hardly capable of carrying the weight laid on it.¹ The hostile judgements upon the credibility of Herodotus, cited by him, have long ago vanished as fuller knowledge has shown us how remarkably good was the historian's information. And to cut out as a gloss the above-quoted statement of Strabo is a heroic expedient which only betrays the Parsi scholar's exceedingly pardonable bias. I cannot stop to discuss the matter here in its later developments, for Sassanian practice

¹ See the criticism of Dr Casartelli, in the *Babylonian and Oriental Record*, 1889—continued in 1890. The bulk of the paper is a discussion of the strange Vedic hymn (*Rv*, x. 10), in which Yamî woos her brother Yama, just as Yimak woos Yim in a Pahlavi *Rivâyet* translated by West (*SBE*, xviii. 418 f.). Dr Casartelli infers that this late Vedic hymn is an attack upon a custom known to prevail in some neighbouring race—one, as I should put it, which was closely akin to the Magi.